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St. Sabina pastor accused, removed

Archdiocese says it is investigating allegation of past abuse; Pfleger calls it 'absolute lie'

By **Evgenia Anastasakos**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Rev. Michael Pfleger has been removed from his ministry at St. Sabina Church in Auburn Gresham, according to the Archdiocese of Chicago, as it investigates an accusation of sexual abuse of a minor from more than 30 years ago.

Pfleger was previously accused of sexual abuse by three men in 2021 and one man in 2022. He vehemently denied the allegations and, after independent investigations, the Archdiocese of Chicago cleared him of wrongdoing.

In a letter to the congregation Saturday, Cardinal Blase J. Cupich said that, in line with the Archdiocese's child protection policies, the allegation has been reported to law enforcement authorities.

"I want to stress that the welfare of the children entrusted to our care is our paramount concern," Cupich wrote. "The Archdiocese of Chicago takes all allegations of sexual misconduct seriously."

Pfleger has served as pastor of St. Sabina Church since 1981. In his time there, he gained a reputation as an outspoken advocate for social justice.

In a statement on Facebook Saturday, Pfleger called the allegations "an absolute lie."

"Let me be clear, sexual abuse is wrong and I realize that the Catholic Church has a long history of not dealing with accusations and has spent a number of years putting strong policies in place, but I have said countless times I believe the current policy is wrong and unfair to the accused priest," Pfleger said in the statement.

Pfleger said the Archdiocese informed him of the allegations on Thursday. The accuser is a woman

See **PASTOR** on Page A4



Adriana, 34, walks near the 4500 block of West Fifth Avenue in Chicago's Garfield Park neighborhood on April 16. Adriana says she has been a sex worker for a little over 10 years and has been arrested on prostitution charges in the past. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Police take different tack in fighting prostitution

Area agencies mix enforcement with help for sex workers who are ready to accept it

By **Sam Charles**
and **Armando L. Sanchez**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

If you're not careful and don't control yourself, Adriana said, "the West Side will consume you. It will eat you up."

Now 34, she's worked as a prostitute for more than 10 years, selling oral sex near the Eisenhower Expressway. The money she earns goes to support her children, Adriana said, as well as her heroin addiction.

Lately, local law enforcement agencies have shifted their focus to prioritize the well-being of sex workers and sex trafficking

victims. But a person's access to the resources and assistance to get out of the sex trade can depend on which law enforcement agency is involved and a person's willingness to cooperate, the Tribune has found.

Soliciting a prostitute was reclassified to a misdemeanor in 2013, and the efforts to arrest johns, the men who patronize sex workers, vary among local police agencies. Chicago police made 189 prostitution-related arrests in 2025 — down from 6,026 in 2001.

The Cook County sheriff's office handles much of the local enforcement of prostitution crimes. In an effort to tamp down

demand, the sheriff's police's special victims unit carries out undercover sting operations across the county, targeting the men who patronize sex workers. The women encountered by the SVU are not arrested or cited, but instead are referred to the sheriff's victim support services division for assistance whenever they are ready to accept it.

TROUBLED TERRITORY

Adriana and scores of other sex workers operate in a small pocket of the West Side, barely within the city limits, on the border between Austin and West Garfield Park, abutting suburban Cicero.

Their territory is just south of the Eisenhower Expressway, roughly bounded by Cicero, Fifth, Lexington and Kostner. The area — half residential, half industrial — is rough by any measure. It is, all day, every day, Chicago's red-light district.

Homeless encampments that serve as places for drug addicts to shoot up line several vacant and overgrown lots. Vehicles with lone male occupants zigzag down side streets and through alleys, the drivers slowing to gawk at women. Occasionally, one will stop and have a brief conversation, and

See **SEX** on Page A2



A young visitor reacts to a passing beluga whale at Shedd Aquarium in Chicago on Thursday. The museum is planning to take in beluga whales from a closed aquarium in Canada. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Shedd Aquarium joins effort to rescue 30 beluga whales

By **Finnegan Belleau**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Shedd Aquarium plans to bring up to 10 beluga whales to Chicago in the next few weeks as part of a rescue operation that will remove 30 belugas from a closed marine park in Canada.

According to a Shedd news release, the current caretakers of

Marineland of Canada, located in Niagara Falls, Ontario, threatened to euthanize the whales.

Johnny Ford, vice president of communications at Shedd Aquarium, said much of the rescue is still subject to change depending on factors such as the whales' health.

"There's still a lot we don't know about the belugas, even having done a couple of personal visits to the

facilities," Ford said. "There's still question marks that we have about their medical history, about their condition."

Shedd, which is currently home to eight belugas, has partnered with four other facilities, including the Georgia Aquarium in Atlanta, SeaWorld San Antonio, SeaWorld

See **WHALES** on Page A3

US launches series of strikes on Iran

Tehran says strait now closed, attacks 5 Gulf Arab states

By **Jon Gambrell**
and **Will Weissert**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — The United States launched several waves of strikes on Iran on Sunday over an Iranian attack on a container ship in the Strait of Hormuz that set it ablaze and left a crew member missing the day before.

Iran responded with attacks on Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan and Oman — the nation on the other side of the strait that

Tehran has pressed to collaborate in managing shipping traffic.

The U.S. military said it was seeking "to degrade" Iran's "ability to attack commercial ships freely transiting" the critical strait.

The statement came after a third round of strikes late Sunday night and into Monday in Iran.

The first wave, on Sunday morning, came in response to an Iranian strike on a container ship in the critical waterway Saturday. Iran responded to those strikes by attacking Gulf Arab states in an escalating cycle of violence that left the negotiations between

See **IRAN** on Page A4

NATION & WORLD

'Irreplaceable' GOP figure lost



JIM WATSON/AFP/GETTY

Washington mourned after the death of Republican Sen. Lindsey Graham, one of one of President Donald Trump's closest allies in Congress and a U.S. foreign policy hawk. **B1**

■ Trump, who called Graham a "true American Patriot," appeared shocked by the lawmaker's sudden passing. **B1**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H:94 L:74
TUE. H:96 L:75
WED. H:96 L:74
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A8
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-9
Crossword B9
Editorials A6
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Obituaries A9
Television B7

179th year No. 194
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